Cape Capital

Mission critical software

Defensible moats versus AI disruption risk

03 MARCH 2026

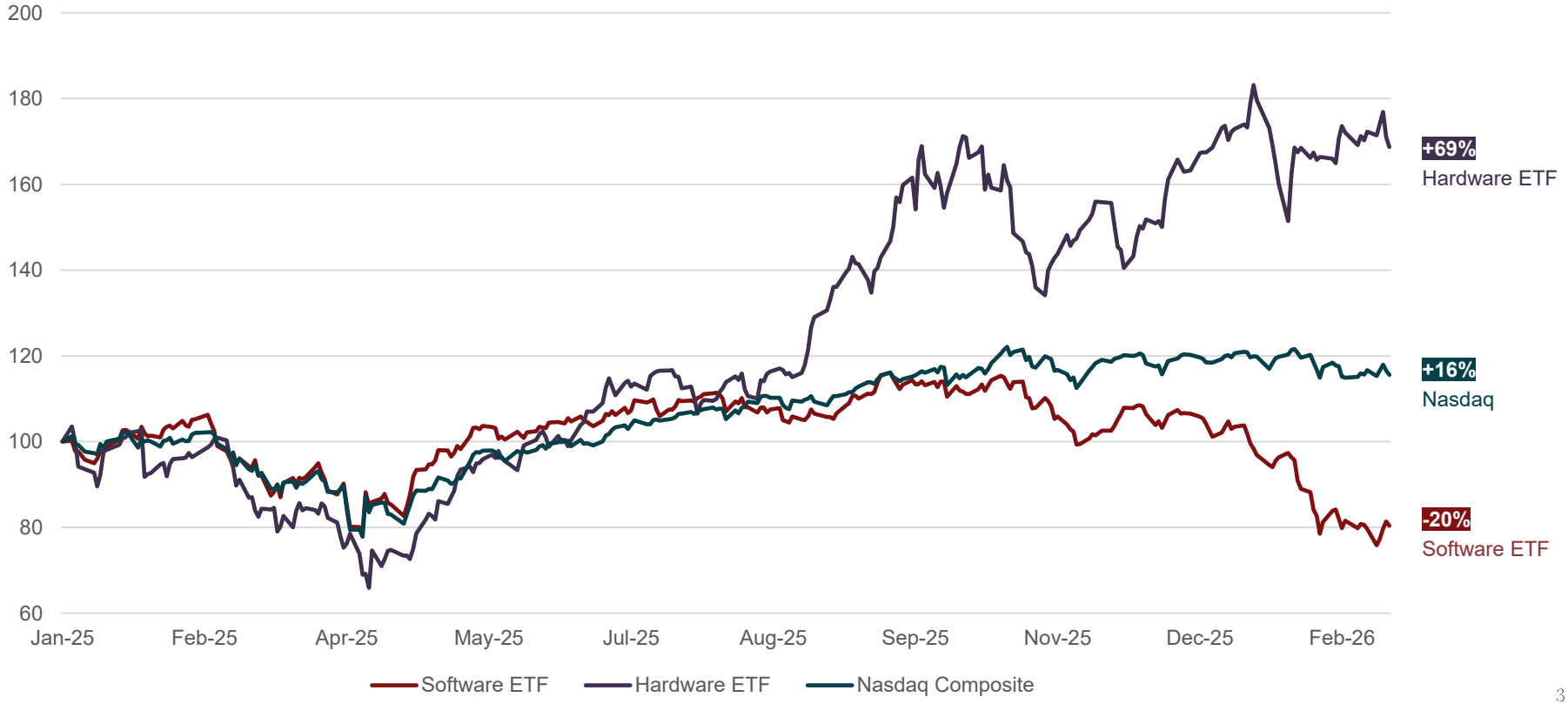
Global IT spend surpasses USD 6tr

- USD 6.15tr total in 2026, +10.8% YoY: Worldwide IT spending is expected to reach USD6.15 trillion in 2026
- Software up ~15% to USD 1.43tr: Gartner expects software to be the second fastest growing tech category, with spending rising nearly 15% year over year to USD1.43 trillion.
- GenAI model spend +80.8%: Projections for generative AI model spending in 2026 remain unchanged, with growth expected at 80.8%.

Category	Spending in 2025 (in millions of dollars)	Growth in 2025 (in percent)	Spending in 2026 (in millions of dollars)	Growth in 2026 (in percent)
Data center systems	496,231	48.9	653.403	3
Terminals	788,335	9.1	836,417	6.1
Software	1,249,509	11.5	1,433,633	13.3
IT services	1,717,590	6.4	1,866,856	8.7
Communication services	1,303,651	3.8	1,365,184	4.7
IT total	**5,555,316**	**10.3**	**6,155,493**	**10.8**

Source: Gartner, February 2026

A story of software, hardware and the Nasdaq



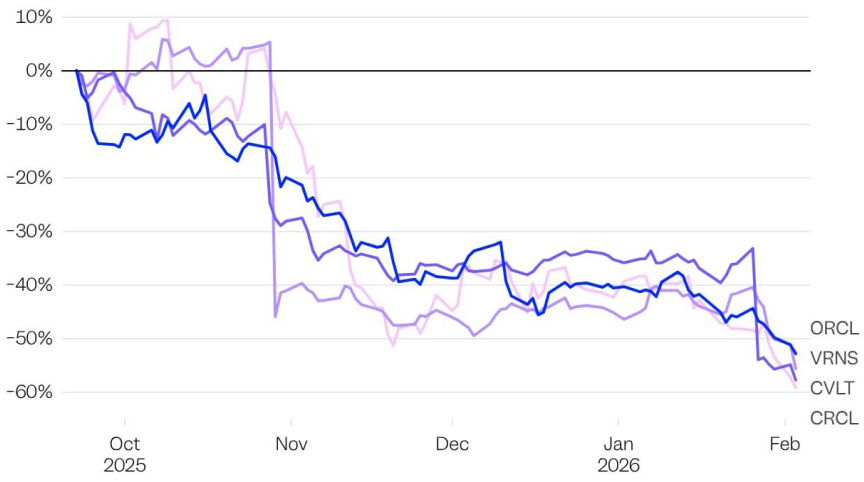
A 47% multiple compression over past 12 months

Software has rerated from 51x to 27x P/E, moving from the most expensive industry in equities to the middle of the pack. Four sectors now trade at a higher multiple.

Industry	2026 P/E	2027 P/E	2025 P/E as of 1Y ago
Media & Entertainment	34.8x	27.1x	33.4x
Automobiles & Components	31.7	24.7	22.8
Semiconductors & Semiconductor Equipment	31.5	23.9	28.4
Capital Goods	30.9	23.6	24.7
Software & Services	**26.9**	**22.1**	**50.6**
Real Estate Management & Development	24.5	20.0	38.0
Consumer Services	23.7	20.2	33.5
Materials	23.4	17.1	27.9
Pharmaceuticals, Biotechnology & Life Sciences	23.3	18.0	30.8
Technology Hardware & Equipment	22.7	19.1	22.1
Transportation	22.1	18.0	19.1
Consumer Staples Distribution & Retail	21.5	19.3	22.0
Consumer Discretionary Distribution & Retail	21.5	18.0	28.1
Commercial & Professional Services	19.8	17.6	23.7
Health Care Equipment & Services	19.6	17.2	24.9
Household & Personal Products	19.1	17.7	23.1
Utilities	19.0	16.5	19.7
Energy	18.8	15.2	14.7
Consumer Durables & Apparel	18.2	15.3	19.3
Food, Beverage & Tobacco	17.4	15.5	18.8
Financial Services	16.4	13.9	21.9
Telecommunication Services	13.0	11.9	14.3
Banks	12.1	10.7	12.6
Insurance	12.0	11.1	13.7

Source: Goldman Sachs, February 2026

Some of the worst returns in software stocks since September 2025 high



Source: Bloomberg

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Business case

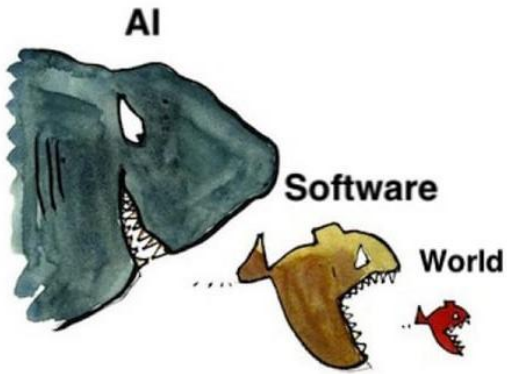
The market is applying an indiscriminate “AI disruption” discount across software, underweighting the resilience of systems-of-record with high switching costs, deep workflow integration, and multi-year contractual revenue.

The narrative arc

From software dominance to AI disruption, two quotes that frame the market's fear.

Wall Street Journal, August 2011

NVIDIA GTC, May 2017



AI versus SaaS: Bull vs Bear case

Bull Case

1. **Sell-off was sentiment, not fundamental**
   SAP, Oracle, and ServiceNow fell 26–40% while posting accelerating subscription growth. The market repriced the narrative, not the numbers.

2. **AI is an upsell, not a replacement**
   Salesforce Agentforce at $800M ARR (+169% YoY) shows AI monetising on top of existing platforms. The AI layer expands ARPU.

3. **Regulatory spend provides a valuation floor**
   NIS2 enforcement is active across the EU in 2026 and SEC cyber rules are live in the US. Cybersecurity has the most defensible near-term revenue visibility.

Bear Case

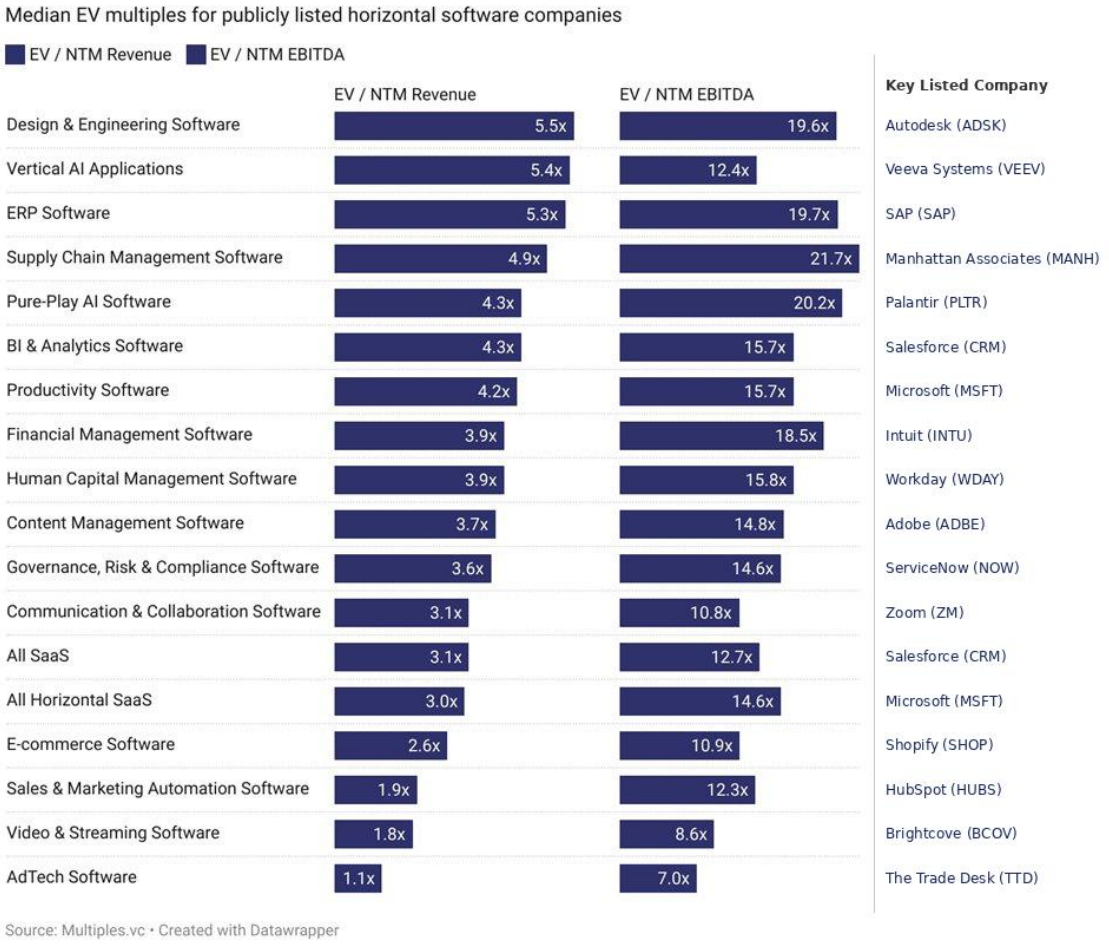
1. **AI is deflationary for software pricing**
   Building a meaningful SaaS product now costs under $10K in compute. Bespoke alternatives will erode incumbent ARPU before AI upsell revenue fills the gap.

2. **Seat-based models are structurally broken**
   Hiring freezes and layoffs directly reduce seats, capping expansion revenue and triggering downsell in CRM, ITSM, and workflow tools.

3. **Fragmented data is the incumbents' trap**
   AI agents are blind when data sits across 50 disconnected apps. This hands a clean opening to unified AI-native challengers.

Horizontal software is the most vulnerable

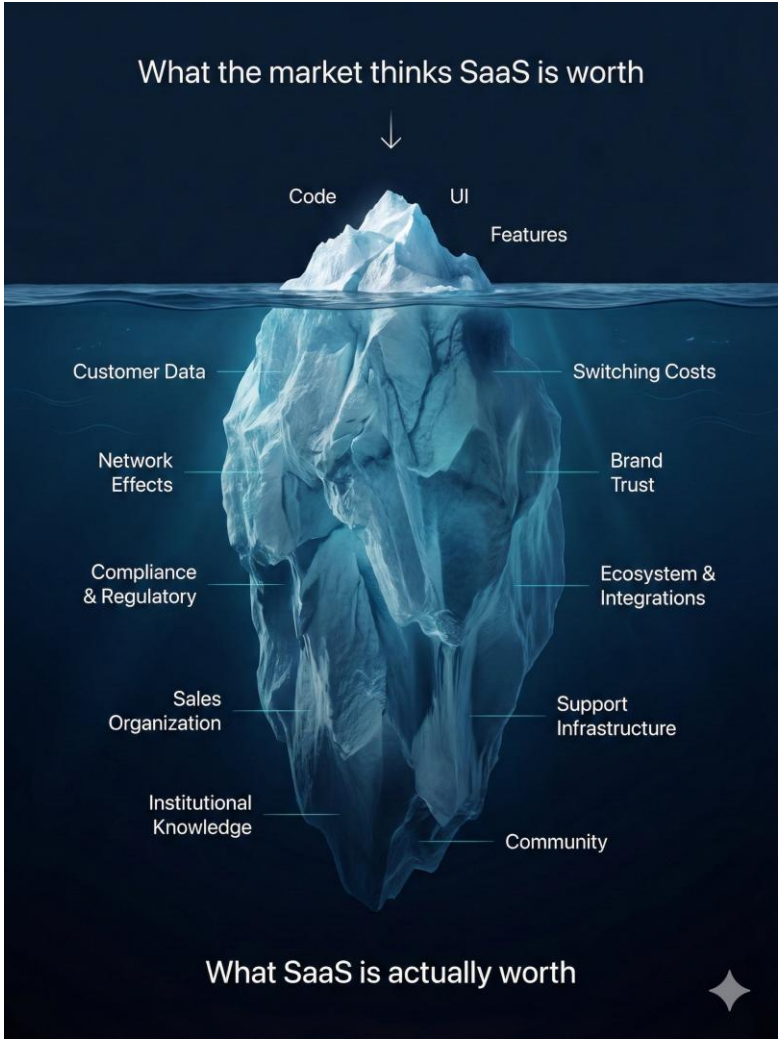
- Horizontal software is designed to be used across a wide variety of industries because it solves a general business problem rather than a niche one. It focuses on broad functionality (like bookkeeping or email) that is universal to almost any type of company.
- Vertical software (also known as "niche" software) is purpose-built for a specific industry or "vertical," such as healthcare, construction, or retail. It includes specialized features and workflows that are only relevant to that particular field.
- ERP stands for Enterprise Resource Planning: Instead of having separate programs for accounting, sales, and warehouse management that don't talk to each other, an ERP brings them all into one "source of truth."



Source: Multiples.vc, November 2025

But SaaS is not just a bundle of code

- The "SaaSpocalypse" thesis reduces software companies to lines of code, ignoring everything below the surface.
- The real moats are customer networks, integration ecosystems, proprietary data, institutional trust, and sales organizations.
- If code is cheap for everyone, the winners will be the companies that are great at everything except the code.

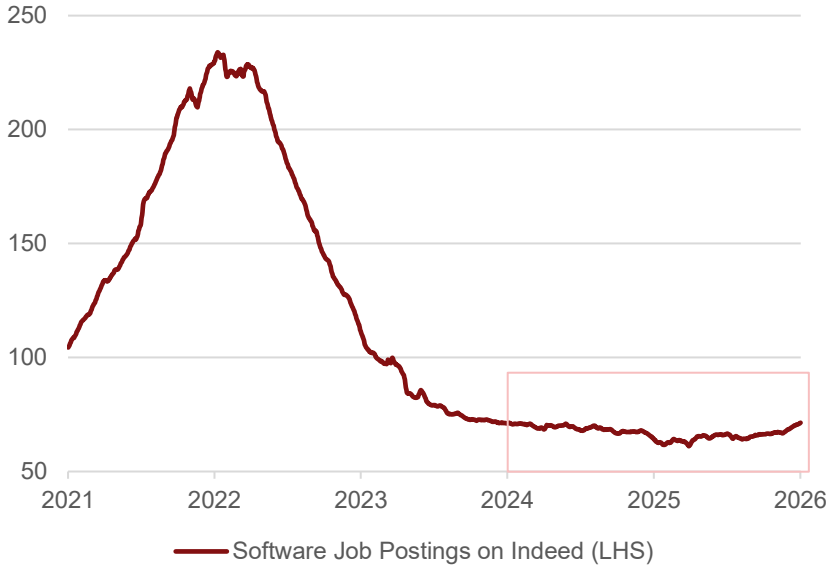


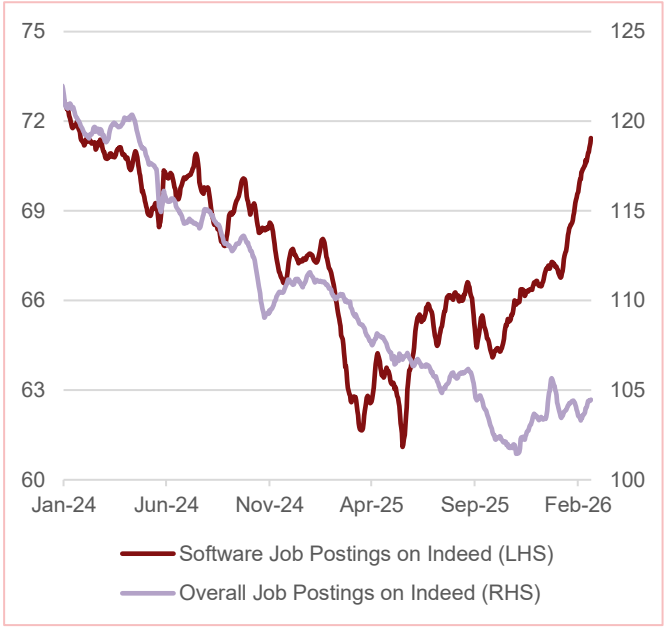
The Jevons Paradox of software?

Software job postings are down ~70% from 2022 peak

However, despite concerns, as software gets cheaper to build, companies will do more, not less, driving both output and hiring

The need for skilled developers isn't going away - it's evolving. It's not man vs. machine, it's man with machine



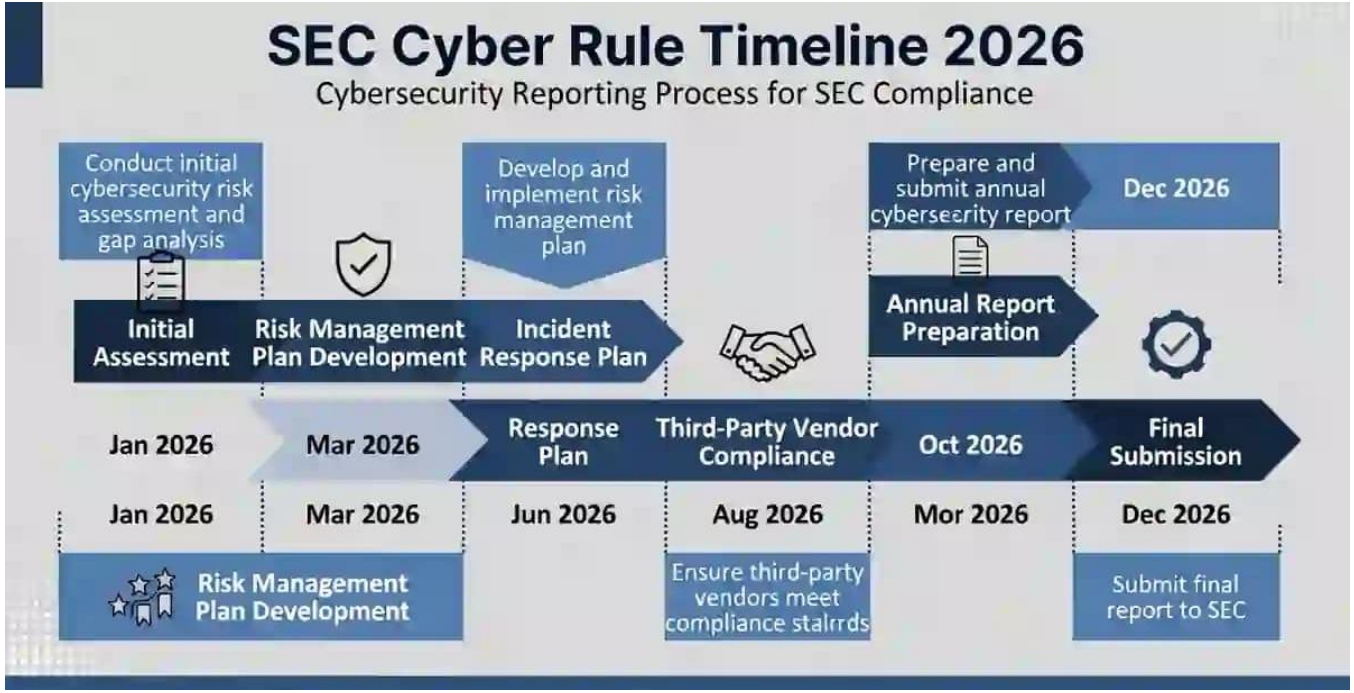


*In all graphs, Feb 1, 2020 = 100

Source: FRED

Special case: Cybersecurity

- Being compliant isn’t optional it is mandatory. No room for mistake.
- AI-driven attacks up 72% YoY, detection windows collapsed to 11 minutes thus it accelerates platform security demand, doesn't commoditize it



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Rule-based stock selection

Mission-critical-software funnel

Systematic and rule-based methodology encompassing both qualitative and quantitative aspects.

- Collected names from RBICS screening and reputable ETFs and Indexes (Goldman Sachs, First Trust, etc..)
- Ensured a market cap of USD 10b or greater
- Scored on AI evaluation, growth, quality, value and momentum
- Final output of top 25 companies

1. Software universe

Names collected from RBICS, ETF and Index screening

2. Inclusion criteria

> USD 10b
Market cap

3. Scored on parameters

45%
AI Evaluation

20% Growth	15% Quality
10% Value	10% Momentum

4. Top 25 companies

High conviction picks representing mission critical software

Example: Veeva Systems, Microsoft, Palo Alto

Veeva powers cloud software for life sciences, Microsoft dominates enterprise productivity, and Palo Alto leads cybersecurity — here is how each score across our key pillars and framework.

Veeva Systems

Healthcare and Pharma Industry Software

1. Software universe

Included from RBICS, ETF and Index screening

2. Inclusion criteria

USD 28bn
Market cap

3. Scored on parameters

43 / 45 AI Evaluation	
3 / 10 Growth	14 / 25 Quality
7 / 15 Value	3 / 5 Momentum

Final score	70 / 100

Microsoft

General and Mixed-Type Software

1. Software universe

Included from RBICS, ETF and Index screening

2. Inclusion criteria

USD 2,900bn
Market cap

3. Scored on parameters

38 / 45 AI Evaluation	
6 / 10 Growth	12 / 25 Quality
5 / 15 Value	3 / 5 Momentum

Final score	64 / 100

Palo Alto

Network Infrastructure Software

1. Software universe

Included from RBICS, ETF and Index screening

2. Inclusion criteria

USD 121bn
Market cap

3. Scored on parameters

35 / 45 AI Evaluation	
4 / 10 Growth	12 / 25 Quality
3 / 15 Value	3 / 5 Momentum

Final score	58 / 100

Top 25 - Names selected

Software (RBICS Level 5)	Name	Score
Other Business Administrative Services	Fair Isaac Corporation	75.8
Enterprise Resource Planning Software	Workday, Inc. Class A	73.5
General Enterprise Management Software	SAP SE	70.3
Healthcare and Pharma Industry Software	Veeva Systems Inc Class A	70.2
General Enterprise Management Software	ServiceNow, Inc.	69.4
Diversified Hosting Services	Oracle Corporation	68.8
Electronic Design Automation Software	Cadence Design Systems, Inc.	67.2
Data Storage Infrastructure Software	Nutanix, Inc.	64.5
General and Mixed-Type Software	Microsoft Corporation	63.7
Finance Industry Software	Guidewire Software, Inc.	63.3
Network Infrastructure Software	Zscaler, Inc.	63.1
Network Infrastructure Software	Dynatrace, Inc.	62.7
Electronic Design Automation Software	Synopsys, Inc.	62.2
Government and Not-For-Profit Industry Software	Palantir Technologies Inc. Class A	62.2
Enterprise Resource Planning Software	Wisetech Global Ltd.	61.8
Network Infrastructure Software	Fortinet, Inc.	61.7
Customer Relationship Management Software	Salesforce, Inc.	61.1
Computer Aided Design Software	Autodesk, Inc.	60.9
Asset Management Software	Samsara, Inc. Class A	59.9
Enterprise Resource Planning Software	Intuit Inc.	59.5
Customer Relationship Management Software	HubSpot, Inc.	59.4
Computer Aided Design Software	Dassault Systemes SE	59.2
Network Infrastructure Software	CrowdStrike Holdings, Inc.	59.0
Finance Industry Software	SS&C Technologies Holdings, Inc.	57.9
Network Infrastructure Software	Palo Alto Networks, Inc.	57.6

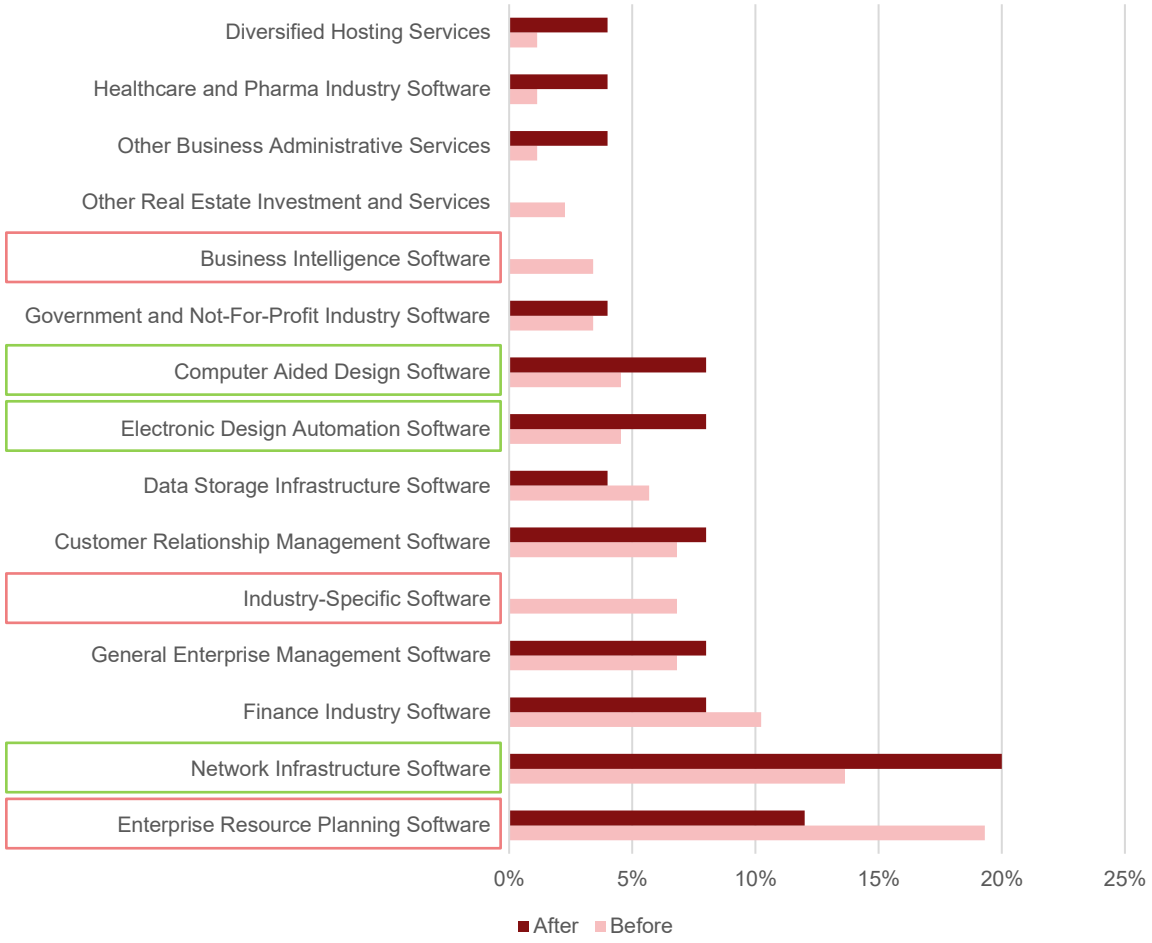
The type of software matters

A clear trend is visible when examining the type of software that makes it in the top 25, some come out as winners, and some as losers.

Network infrastructure software
- Palo Alto
- CrowdStrike

Electronic design automation software
- Synopsis
- Cadence Design Systems

Computer aided design software
- Dassault Systemes
- Autodesk



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